

tell my parents I would be taking control of the account, all in a bid to prove to myself that I was responsible girlfriend material. I joked to Mum and Dad that it hinged on the hope that they hadn't siphoned off a portion of my salary to pay for a baby boomer cruise around the Caribbean, but the reality was much more serious. I felt the time was right for me to take control of my finances, so I could show the bank the savings were my own. This was my first true test since I'd started the plan about 18 months before.

I soon discovered that I was in an infatuation bubble, and was far from ready. In a little over a week, I chewed through almost \$1000 buying clothes and splashing out on dates that were above my budget by requesting extra pocket money from my parents. They intensely quizzed me as to why I needed the additional funds, but I can now see they were letting me learn the hard way. The point of the Pocket Money Savings Plan is to enforce good money habits, no matter what the circumstances, and I had failed a crucial early test.

The guilt I felt after that binge was more painful than the inevitable break-up with the guy. He broke it off, citing 'the money thing'. With my heart in a vice, I promptly put the squeeze, just as hard, back on my budget. I found that healing solo over a tub of ice-cream and rented movies is a cheap night in, and I was soon back on track, mentally and financially. After that, I was immediately upfront with gentlemen about my savings plan of attack. One said he admired my conviction and offered to cook for me when pocket money was low. The next was unperturbed, and went halves with me in a spaghetti marinara for lunch. It was a lesson in honesty.

Home ownership has always been presented as a joint venture, especially by mortgage advertisements that show smiling couples shaking hands with a navy-suited bank manager. As if Tinder wasn't bad enough, singles have to save harder than ever to afford a first home. I never imagined I would be doing it alone. As the years progress and finding a partner increasingly becomes an act of compromise, so too do the options for getting a foot on the property ladder.

A 2016 survey of 500 aspiring home buyers by property consultants First Home Buyers Australia found that 71 per cent desired to buy a first home with a partner. Yet the delay in marriage among Gen Y is one factor putting home ownership on hold. The last census revealed the median age that men get married is 31.9 years, and 29.9 years for women. We are getting hitched, having babies and settling down later than our mums and